

◀ AN ASSAULT ON FORTIFICATIONS

A 14th century European artist's representation of a siege in progress shows men-at-arms in mail armour and surcoats attempting to scale walls, while archers with longbows provide covering fire. Both sides are suffering heavy casualties in this perilous assault.

KEY EVENTS

11TH–15TH CENTURY

■ **c.1078–90** William the Conqueror builds stone keep castles in London and Rochester, England.

■ **1096–99** The First Crusade introduces western European soldiers to the advanced fortifications of the eastern Mediterranean.

■ **1120s–1130s** The counterweight trebuchet comes into use in battles between Muslims and Christians, in Palestine and Syria.

■ **1143** The order of the Knights Hospitaller begin turning the Krak des Chevaliers, in Syria, into the most impressive crusader castle.

■ **1196** Construction of Chateau Gaillard in Normandy begins – an early example of a series of high walls surrounding a central keep.

■ **c.1450** Used in sieges by the French and the Ottoman Turks, cannon render medieval stone fortifications obsolete.



“The armed men... delivered a **terrific assault**, firing stones and missiles... from their **ballistas and engines**”

ITINERARIUM REGIS RICARDI, DESCRIBING THE 1191 SIEGE OF ACRE, c.1220